

Redesigning Software with an AI Agent

Purpose. Today most software is a tool that helps a person do work. An AI agent is different: you give it a goal, and it can take steps on its own to reach it. Your task is to redesign a software product around a customer goal, then decide whether AI makes the company that sells it today stronger or weaker.

Instructions. Work with your team. Do not use an LLM or outside sources. Use what you know about the product and the ideas from class.

You have **12 minutes** to talk it through. Choose one person to give a **90-second explanation to the class**.

Part 1: Choose a Product and Customer Goal

Pick a software product your team knows well — for example:

Zoom Microsoft Teams Slack Notion Shopify Canva Moodle

Now describe the customer’s real goal — what they are trying to get done — not the feature they click on.

- **Not:** “Zoom video meetings” **Better:** “Help teams make decisions and finish the follow-up tasks”
- **Not:** “Salesforce keeps customer records” **Better:** “Help sales teams find and close deals faster”

Part 2: Design the Agent

Imagine the simplest AI agent that could serve this goal. Talk through two things:

- **What can the agent do on its own?** What actions does it take — send, schedule, update, order, reply?
- **Where must a person step in?** Where does someone have to approve, stop, or correct it before something happens?

Part 3: Does AI Make the Company Stronger or Weaker?

When software can act on its own, some of a company’s advantages lose value and others gain value.

Example (Canva). The template gallery matters *less* if the agent just makes the design for you. The brand colours, logos, and past designs you have saved matter *more*, because the agent needs them to do the job well.

Now for your product, name:

1. One advantage that becomes **less important**.
2. One advantage that becomes **more important**.
3. Why each one changes.

Final Judgment

Choose the statement that best fits the company's future:

1. **Weaker — open to disruption.** A new AI-first competitor could replace much of the product.
2. **Still needed.** The company controls data, workflows, permissions, or customer trust that are hard to copy.
3. **Stronger.** Customers would rather get the AI agent from a company they already trust with important information and actions.

Your Team's Report

Prepare a 90-second discussion answering three questions:

1. What goal does your agent pursue, and what can it do on its own?
2. Where must a person approve, stop, or correct it?
3. Is the company weaker, still needed, or stronger — and what assumption matters most to your answer?

Questions to Guide Discussion

- Does the agent rely on data or permissions the existing company controls?
- Could a new competitor copy those advantages easily?
- What is the biggest risk if the agent gets something wrong?